intellectual Swami Vivekananda to declare in exasperation in 1897, ‘Was there ever a sillier thing before in the world than what I saw in Malabar country? The poor Pariah is not allowed to pass through the same street as the high-caste man, but if he changes his name to a hodge-podge English name, it is all right; or to a Mohammedan name, it is all right. What inference would you draw except that these Malabaris are all lunatics, their homes so many lunatic asylums, and they are to be treated with derision by every race in India until they mend their manners.’[17]

Ayyan Kali’s first act of public protest against this injustice took place in 1893 when he bought a bullock cart – the ownership of which was forbidden to untouchables such as himself – dressed himself in clothing traditionally worn only by Nairs and then rode the cart down a temple road closed to untouchables. Other such blasphemous and officially illegal acts of protest followed, often provoking violent retaliation, but by 1900 the Pulayars had won the right to use most roads in Travancore State other than those controlled by the most orthodox Shaiva temples.

By 1904 state education had been introduced in Travancore but untouchables continued to be refused admittance. In 1915 Ayyan Kali’s efforts to enrol a Pulayar girl in a government school in Ooruttambalam, outside Trivandrum, were met by violent opposition from the local Nairs, who burned down the school to prevent it being polluted. Ayyan Kali responded by organising a withdrawal of labour by the local agricultural workers – said to be the first organised strike in South India – which ended only when the Government of Travancore agreed to pass legislation lifting all restrictions on access to education.

Two basic human rights still continued to be denied to the lower castes and untouchables of Travancore: freedom of movement and temple access. This led to what became known throughout India as the Vaikom satyagraha, taking its